

OPPOSITION SCOUT REPORT

Barnsley FC

League One · 2025–26

First Team Analyst

Rayan Nasser

Submitted

5 May 2026

Methodology & Scope

How this report was built and what to expect inside

- Tactical observations drawn from Luton Town vs Barnsley footage (25 April 2026), assumed representative for the duration of this analysis.
- Selection patterns and statistical context drawn from 45 League One matches in the 2025–26 season under Conor Hourihane.
- Cup competitions excluded to control for rotation; data window closes at the Northampton match (28 April 2026).
- Each finding is paired with an exploitable opportunity or coaching instruction — observation alone is not the deliverable.
- Visuals are sourced from Sofascore, FotMob, and WhoScored event data. Methodology details available in Appendix.

Executive Summary

Six findings the manager should walk into the meeting with

- Predominantly 4-2-3-1 in possession (82% of L1 matches), morphing to a 4-1-3-2 out of possession with a 3-2 high press on goal kicks.
- Asymmetric build-up: #7 (O'Keeffe) provides high/wide width on the right; #32 (Earl) inverts from left-back to form a back three. #19 (Cleary) holds width on the left.
- #19 Cleary is the danger: 7 goals, 13 assists in League One. Primary wide outlet, cuts inside onto right foot, scored from a similar move at Luton.
- #32 Earl is the exploitable target: vulnerable in 1v1s and recovery moments. Compounded when #19 stays high — left side becomes their structural weakness.
- Press has a structural gap: between the single pivot (#48 Connell) and the three advanced midfielders. Bypassing the first line opens space in front of #48.
- Set piece warning: front-post cluster routines on attacking corners (#18 peel run); aggressive man-marking that breaks down on second balls when defending.

Recent Form

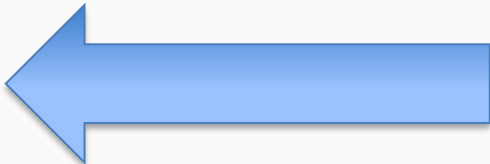
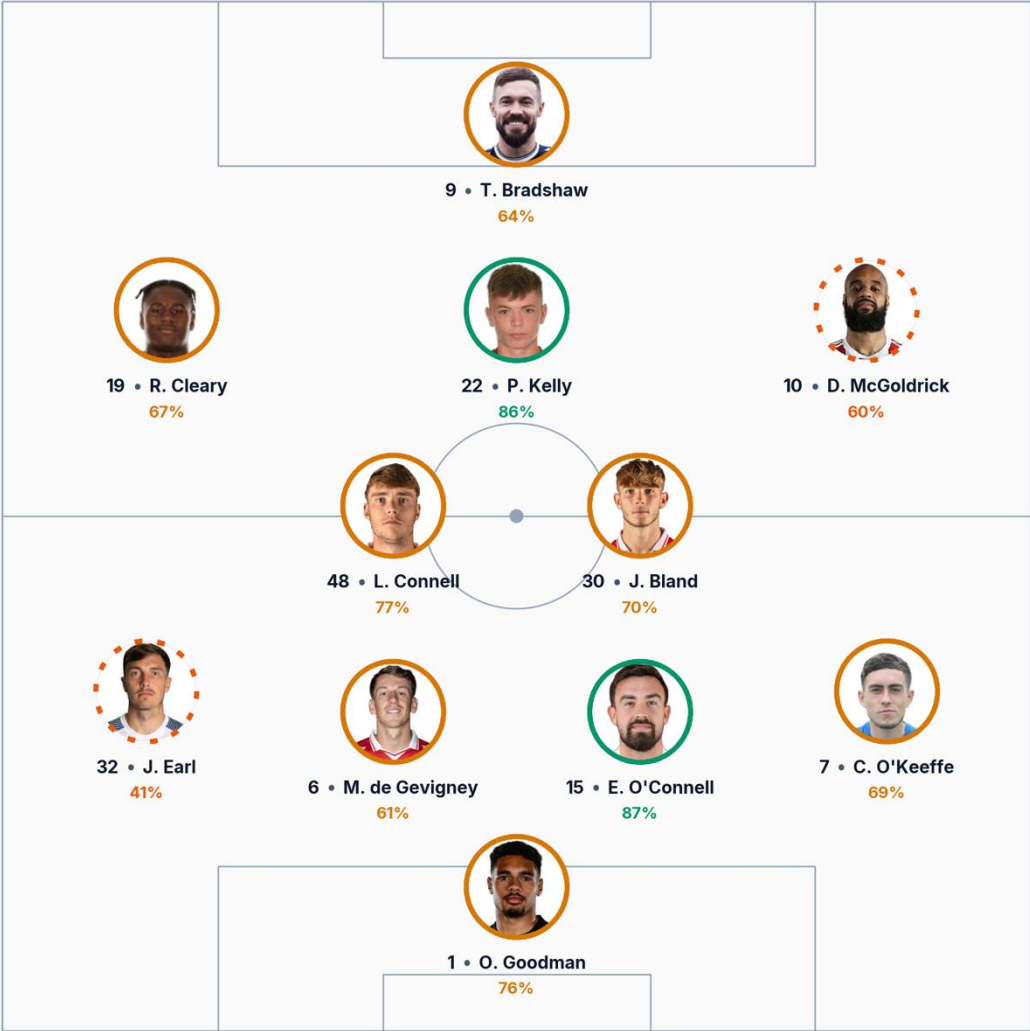
Last 8 League One matches, with season context and contextual notes

03 APR	06 APR	11 APR	14 APR	18 APR	21 APR	25 APR	28 APR
							
Burton (A)	Plymouth (H)	Rotherham (A)	Port Vale (A)	Bradford (H)	Stevenage (A)	Luton (A)	Northampton (A)
1 – 1	0 – 3	3 – 1	0 – 0	2 – 2	0 – 1	1 – 2	1 – 0
D	L	W	D	D	L	L	W

15th	59 pts	-15.5	CONTEXT
League Position	From 46 matches	xG Difference	Manager departing
24 teams	15W · 14D · 17L	20th in League One	Conor Hourihane mutually departing end of season (announced 18 Apr)
			Top scorer sold mid-season
			Davis Keillor-Dunn (13 goals) departed in January McGoldrick (15 G) and Bradshaw filling the gap

Predicted XI

Likely starting eleven, weighted toward most recent League One matches



HOW TO READ

Each player's **percentage** shows their **probability** of starting, weighted by recency.

Ring colours indicate selection **confidence**:

- Solid green** Nailed ($\geq 80\%$)
- Solid amber** Probable (60–80%)
- Dashed amber** Rotational (40–60%)
- Dashed grey** Uncertain ($<40\%$)

Methodology: see Appendix A.

Rotation & Alternatives

Position-by-position alternatives if selection changes

POS		PRIMARY	START %	TIER		ALTERNATIVE	%
GK	1	Owen Goodman	76%	Probable	1	Murphy Cooper	11%
RB	7	Corey O'Keeffe	69%	Probable	27	Tennai Watson	34%
RCB	15	Eoghan O'Connell	87%	Nailed	4	Marc Roberts	27%
LCB	6	Maël de Gevigney	61%	Probable	4	Marc Roberts	27%
LB	32	Josh Earl	41%	Rotational	14	Nathanael Ogbeta	9%
DM	48	Luca Connell	77%	Probable	8	Adam Phillips	54%
CM	30	Jonathan Bland	70%	Probable	45	Vimal Yoganathan	49%
LW	19	Reyes Cleary	67%	Probable	18	Scott Banks	58%
CAM	22	Patrick Kelly	86%	Nailed	8	Adam Phillips	54%
RW	10	David McGoldrick	60%	Rotational	8	Adam Phillips	54%
ST	9	Tom Bradshaw	64%	Probable	10	David McGoldrick	60%

CB pairing is settled - plan against O'Connell + de Gevigney. The highest-confidence pairing on the slide. Roberts is the alternate at both but won't break the pair.

Kelly and Cleary are the two attacking certainties - Kelly nailed at #10, Cleary highly probable on the left. Our defensive plan against #19 and #22 needs to be detailed.

Right of the front three is live - Phillips started this role at Luton and scored. McGoldrick has the higher percentage on recency, but Phillips is the more dangerous and more recent option. Our right-back covers both profiles.

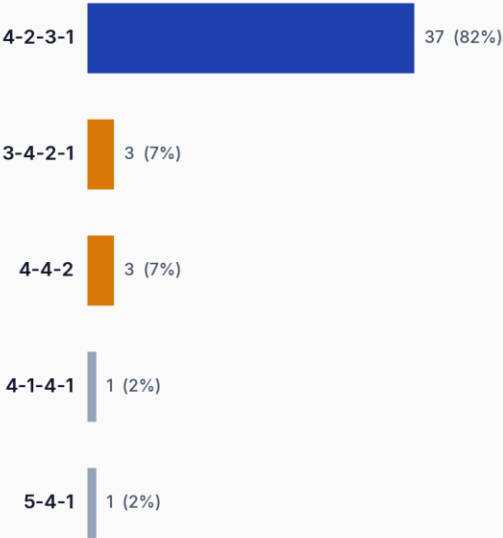
Formation & Shape

Predominantly 4-2-3-1 across the season



Formation distribution

2025–26 League One · 45 matches with lineup data



PLAN FOR 4-2-3-1

82% of league matches use this shape. A brief 5-game spell on a back three (3-4-2-1 / 4-4-2) in mid-January was abandoned. Hourihane has used 4-2-3-1 in 16 of the last 17 league matches.

IN POSSESSION

How Barnsley construct, progress, and create including the principles that drive their attacking shape.

Build-up: asymmetric back three with inverted left-back

How Barnsley construct their attacking shape from goal kicks and settled possession



OBSERVATION

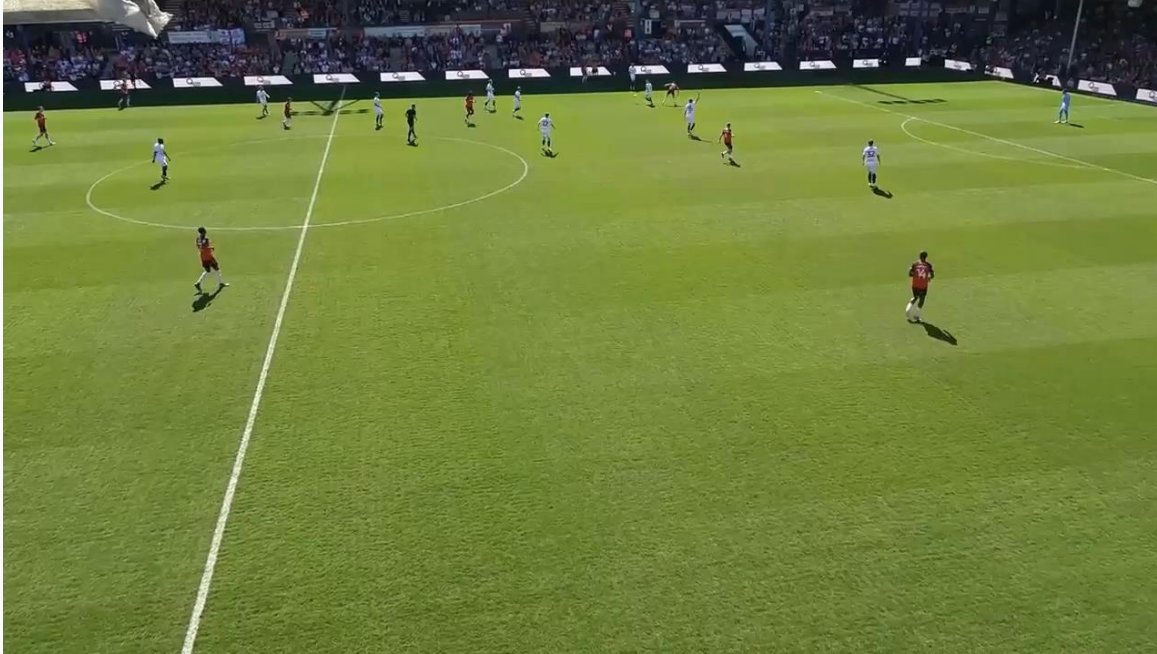
- Recurring build-up theme: #32 (Earl) tucks inside from left-back to form a back three with the centre-backs.
- #7 (O'Keeffe) pushes higher and wider on the right to provide depth and width.
- Result: asymmetric attacking shape. Wide and advanced on the right; narrow and supportive on the left.
- Consistent across multiple sequences — appears to be a principle, not opponent-driven. supports rest defence on the left and gives them an extra man centrally during build-up.

HOW WE HANDLE

- *Left winger must account for #32 appearing centrally rather than wide, and adjust pressing angles accordingly.*
- *Pressing trigger: ball travels to #6 (LCB) → press hard, the inverted lane is shorter than it looks (shorter and more visible passing option, but pressing #6 hard limits his time to find the inverted lane)*

#22 Kelly: the free man between the lines

The connecting role that triggers Barnsley's most dangerous attacking moves



OBSERVATION

- #22 (Kelly) operates nominally as CAM but consistently drops deeper to connect possession.
- In these moments he becomes the free player in midfield — links the back four to the attacking front and creates a temporary numerical superiority.
- The trigger to watch: he was directly responsible for the goal-creating move at Luton. Receiving unmarked from #32 before turning and starting the move that ended in the rebound finish.



HOW WE HANDLE

- A defensive midfielder must follow #22 when he drops.
- If he turns on the half-turn in front of our back line, Barnsley progress immediately.

#19 Cleary: dominant wide outlet on the left

Where Barnsley's possession ends — and how their goals get created



OBSERVATION

- Width in possession is asymmetric. Cleary provides it on the left from his wide-forward position.
- Repeatedly targeted as the progression target — receives driven passes from CBs and the double pivot when Barnsley want to break the lines.
- Holds his width close to the touchline throughout possession; cuts inside onto right foot to shoot or play across goal.
- Season data: 7 goals, 13 assists in League One — top creator in the squad and at the 81st percentile for chances created among players in his position group.



HOW WE HANDLE

- *Cleary cannot be allowed to receive in space and turn inside.*
- *Right-back engages early. Help from RCM is essential.*
- *Force him outside — toward the byline, away from his right foot.*

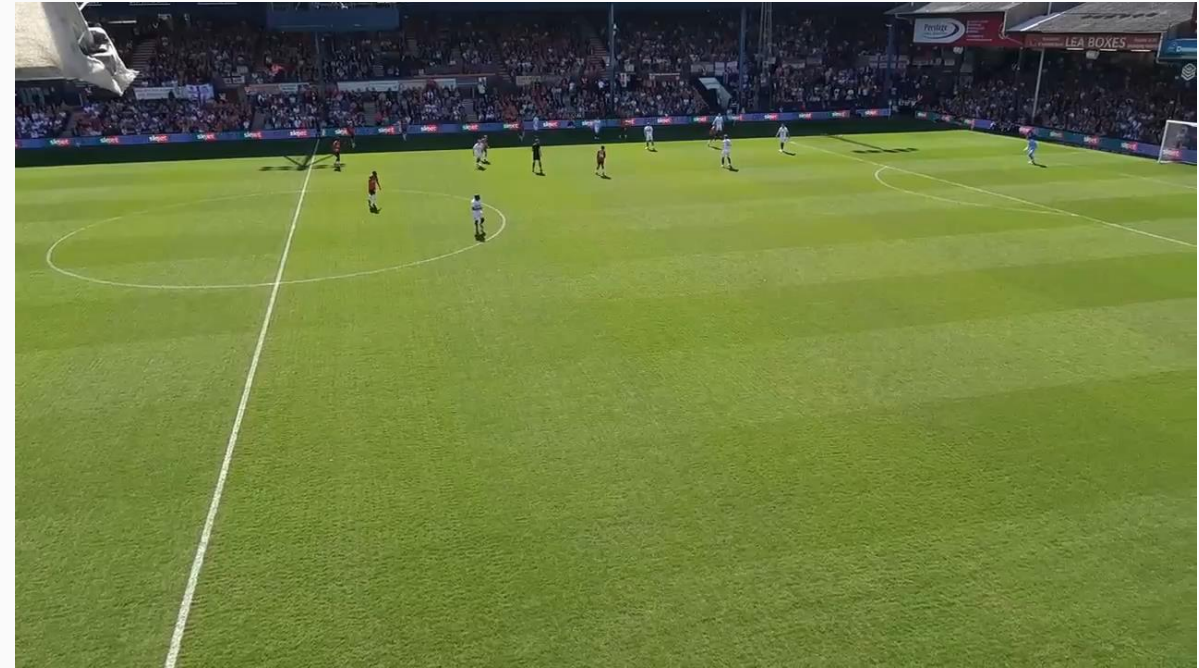
Goalkeeper goes long: distribution behaviour

When Barnsley recycle to Goodman, expect direct distribution



OBSERVATION

- When possession is recycled back to #1 Goodman, he frequently plays long and direct.
- Pattern was consistent across multiple sequences in the Luton match. Appears reflexive rather than situational.
- Confirmed by season data: 5th in League One for accurate long balls per match (26.4) - among the most direct distribution profiles in the division.

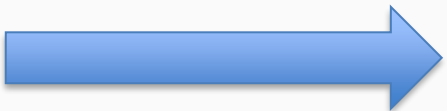
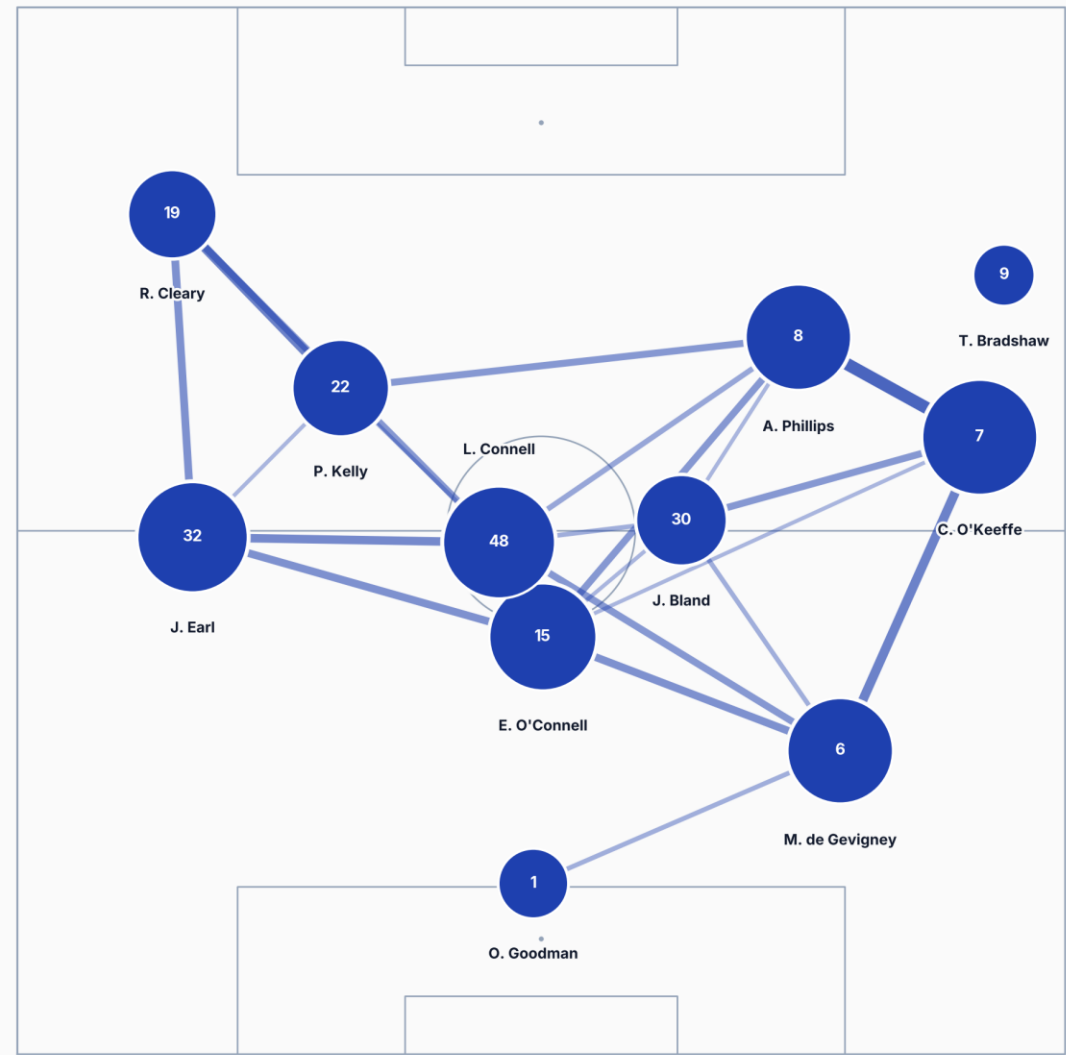


HOW WE HANDLE

- *When ball is recycled to Goodman, drop our high line — long balls require defenders facing the right way.*
- *Forward press recovers into shape; chasing the keeper is unproductive when he goes long.*
- *Compete in the air — direct distribution likely targets central area or #19 wide left.*
- *Win the second ball — when the long ball lands, the next contest is where we regain or concede territory.*

Pass Network — How They Build

Successful starter-to-starter passes pre-first-substitution, Luton vs Barnsley



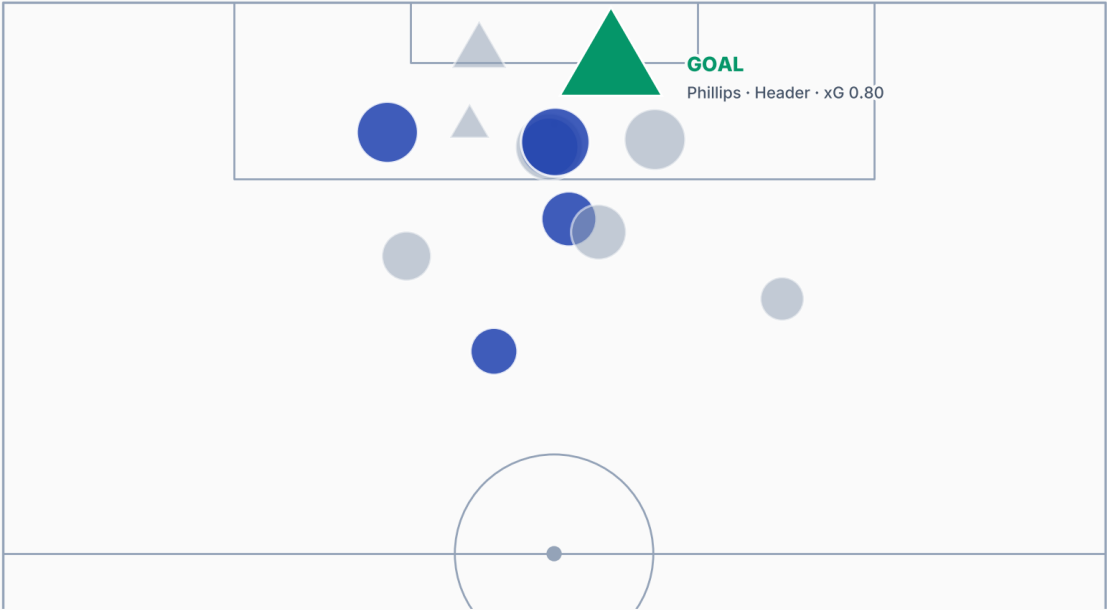
KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Right-side dominance: Phillips ↔ O'Keeffe is the thickest single connection in the network.
- Bradshaw is structurally isolated — receives few passes, plays as the long-ball target.
- Goodman rarely involved in build-up — confirms direct distribution behaviour.
- Cleary high and wide left, fed from multiple sources rather than one dominant link.

Note: Node size = pass volume. Line thickness = passes between pair. Threshold ≥ 3 passes.

Shot Map — Where the Chances Came From

13 shots, 1.69 xG. One high-quality chance scored - most others were speculative.



Match summary

Barnsley shots, Luton (A) — 25 April 2026

13 **1.69**

SHOTS

XG

6

1

ON TARGET

GOAL

Situation

Open play 8

Set pieces 5

How to read

● Goal

● On target / saved

● Off target / blocked

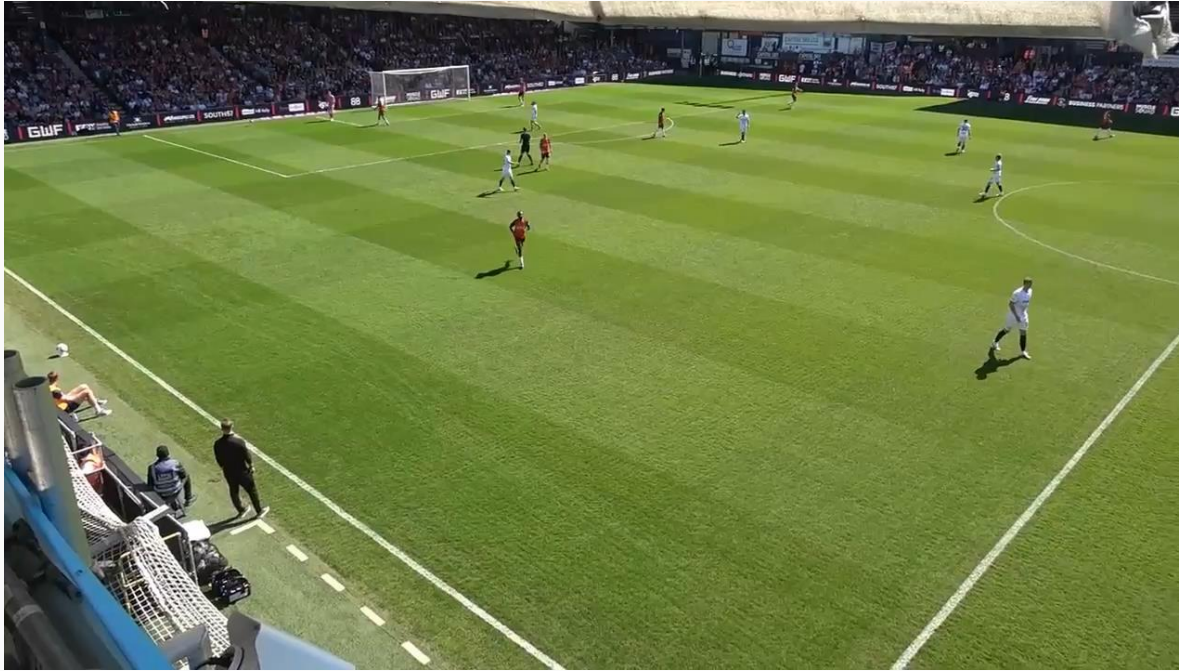
● foot ▲ header · marker size = xG

OUT OF POSSESSION

Barnsley defensive structure, pressing triggers, and the structural gap that makes them vulnerable to play through.

OOP: 4-1-3-2 press, 3-2 high structure on goal kicks

How Barnsley's defensive shape morphs from their 4-2-3-1 base



OBSERVATION

- Out of possession Barnsley shift from 4-2-3-1 to 4-1-3-2. the front pair tries to limit central passing options to the GK and CBs.
- #48 (Connell) holds as single pivot; #30 steps up alongside #8 and #22 to form the second line.
- Above them, #19 and #9 press the centre-backs Once they receive
- Against goal kicks: 3-2 high press. #19 and #9 on the edge of the box; #22, #8, #30 form the line behind. blocking central passing lanes into midfield.

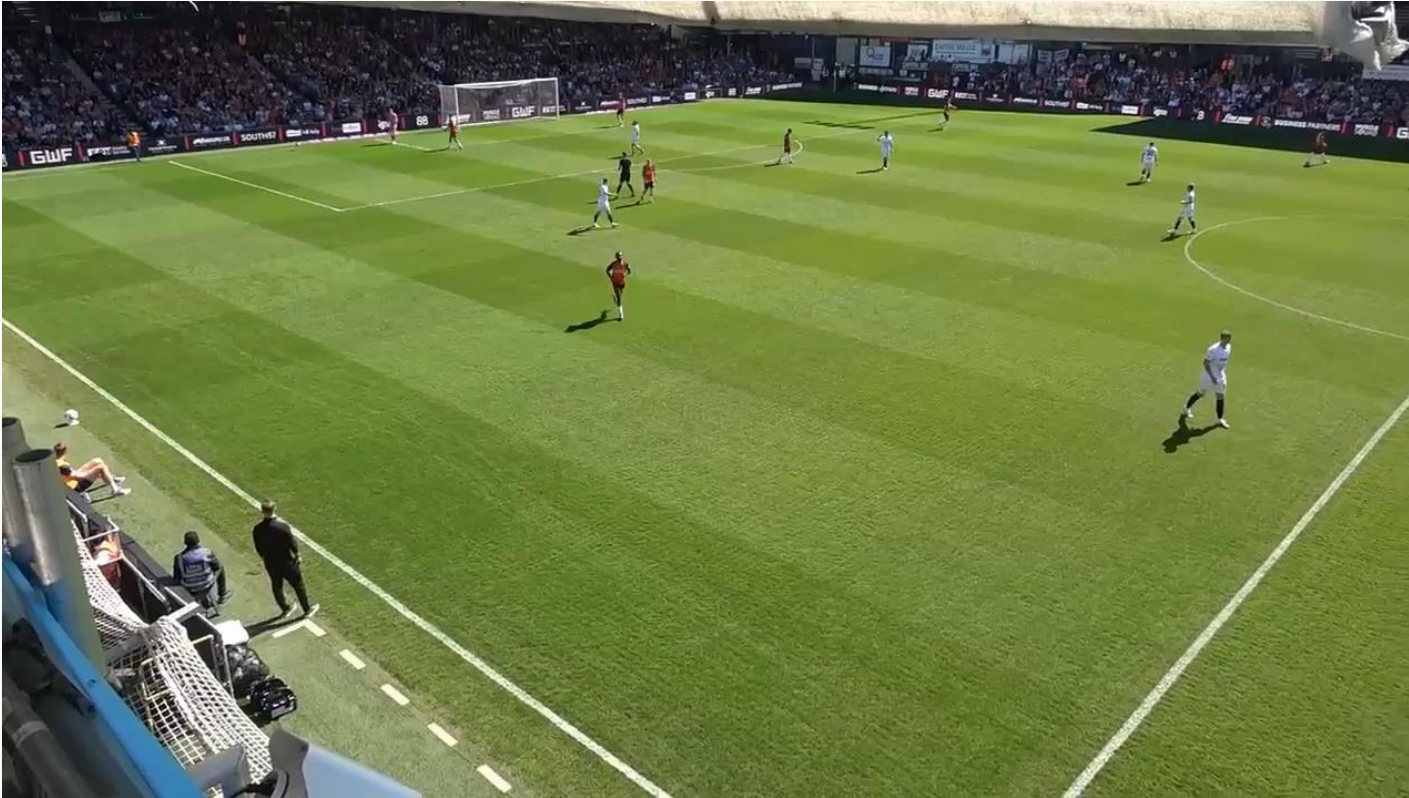


HOW WE HANDLE

- *Avoid forcing central passes into the areas Barnsley screen.*
- *Play wide from the GK to access our fullback early.*
- *Or go long to bypass the first two pressing lines (target the channel between their FB and CB).*
- *Or drop our AM to create a temporary central superiority.*

The gap between #48 and the advanced midfielders

The single most exploitable feature of their pressing structure



OBSERVATION

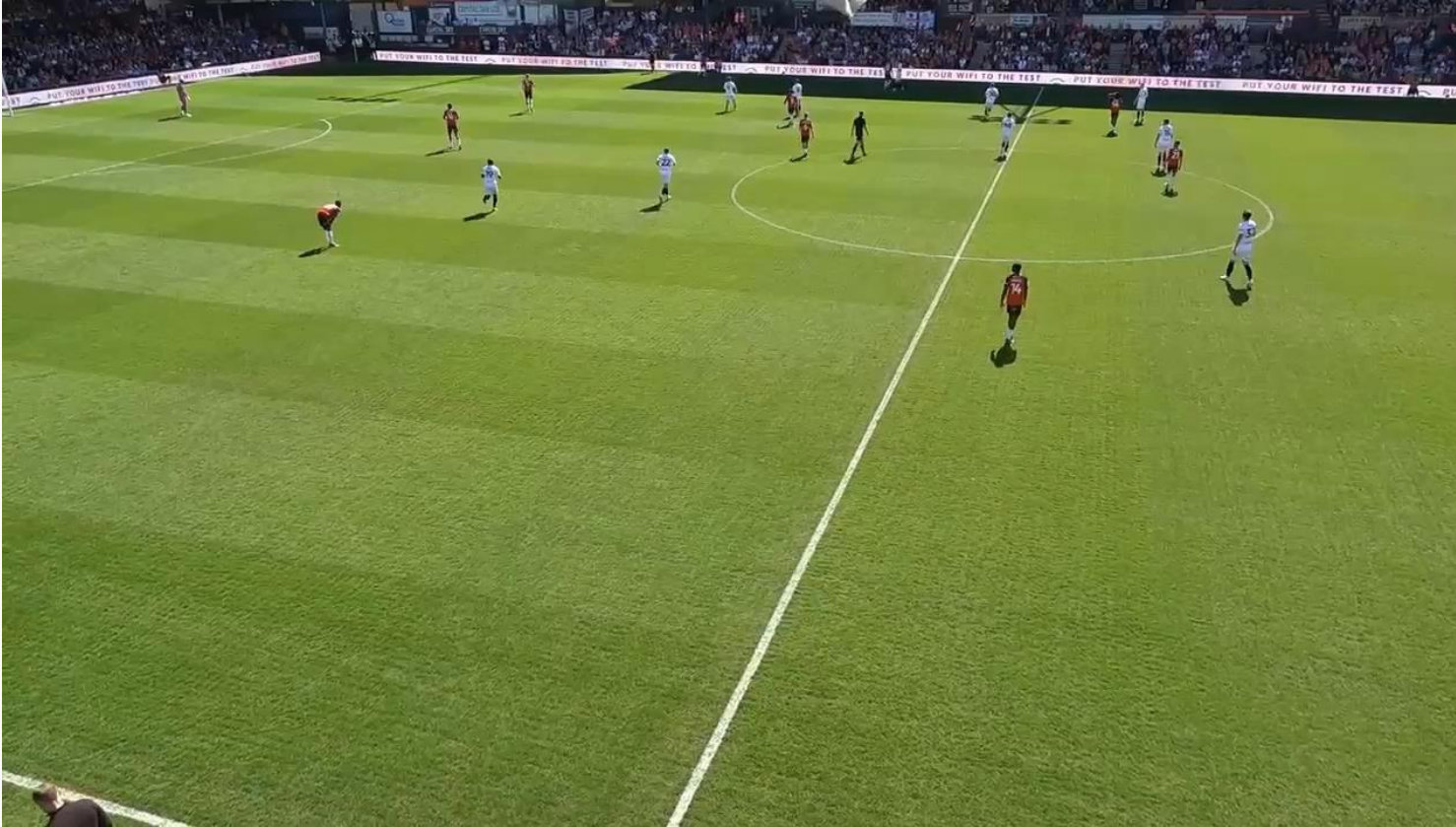
- Noticeable vertical gap between #48 (single pivot) and the three advanced mids (#8, #22, #30).
- If we play through or around the first pressure, the space either side or in front of #48 becomes accessible.
- Recurring positional vulnerability, not a one-off lapse.

HOW WE HANDLE

- *Our central or attacking midfielder should immediately scan for #48's position when we bypass the first line.*
- *Receive in front of him with a forward-facing body shape — attack the back four with momentum.*
- *This is the inverse of what they do to us. Same principle, exploited the other way.*

Recovery shape: high regain, low recover

Where their bodies go when their first press is bypassed



OBSERVATION

- When opposition plays through their first pressure, Barnsley recover quickly — drop bodies behind the ball.
- #9 (Bradshaw) and #19 (Cleary) consistently remain higher as transition outlet options.
- #22 and #8 carry visible defensive responsibility, dropping to support midfield and fullback areas.
- Behind everyone, #48 and #30 hold deeper to protect the back four.

HOW WE HANDLE

- *If we win the ball during their press, look immediately for the forward outlet — they leave #9 and #19 high.*
- *Our midfielders must recognise this transitional moment instantly.*
- *Either play forward to break their pressure entirely, or recycle and reset cleanly.*

Where Barnsley get hurt defensively

Two recurring patterns where their shape breaks



OBSERVATION

- **Pattern 1:** When #7 (O'Keeffe) steps high and misses his pressure, the back three is forced wide; #6 shifts to cover the right and a gap opens in the right half-space behind the line.
- **Pattern 2:** During settled possession, Barnsley's CBs (#15 and #6) often hold high beyond the halfway line. When possession is lost, the space behind the defensive line is immediately available.
- Confirmed by season data: 22nd in League One for xG conceded (71.6) — one of the worst defensive records in the division for chance quality conceded.



HOW WE HANDLE

- *Bait #7 into stepping out — controlled receiving body shape, draw him in, release into the space.*
- *Counter-pressing in their build-up zone is high-value: regain near their CBs while their line is high creates direct attacking access.*

TRANSITIONS

The seconds after possession changes hands — where Barnsley get hurt and where we attack.

Both fullbacks struggle to recover

How Barnsley defend the seconds after losing the ball



OBSERVATION

- After turnovers, both fullbacks are exposed during recovery moments.
- #7 is slow to react and caught on the back foot, delays his recovery run when transition develops.
- #32 is closer to the action but lacks acceleration — flat-footed in the first few steps.
- The exposure compounds when #19 doesn't track back: #32 is left to manage both the wide runner and the inside runner alone.

HOW WE HANDLE

- *When we win the ball, our right-sided forward immediately attacks the channel outside #32.*
- *Commit a runner inside as well — create a 2v1 against an isolated fullback who lacks recovery pace.*
- *The first 3-5 seconds after we win the ball is the highest-value window — once #32 and #6 reset, the opportunity closes.*
- *Players to watch our right side: #19 will not recover, but #22 (Kelly) and #30 (Bland) might drop in. Our ball-carriers must keep their head up and recognise which support is closing.*

Left-side overload: the structural exploit

The single most actionable finding in this report



OBSERVATION

- Barnsley's left side combines two weaknesses into one structural exploit:
- #19 (Cleary) stays high in transition rather than tracking back leaves #32 isolated.
- #32 (Earl) lacks recovery pace and 1v1 defensive quality (strong in contact (99th percentile aerial duels) but flat-footed at speed)
- Combined effect: gap opens between #32 and #6 (LCB) when both are stretched.
- Repeatable structural weakness — overloads on Barnsley's left force #32 into 1v1 or 2v1 defensive actions he cannot win.

HOW WE HANDLE

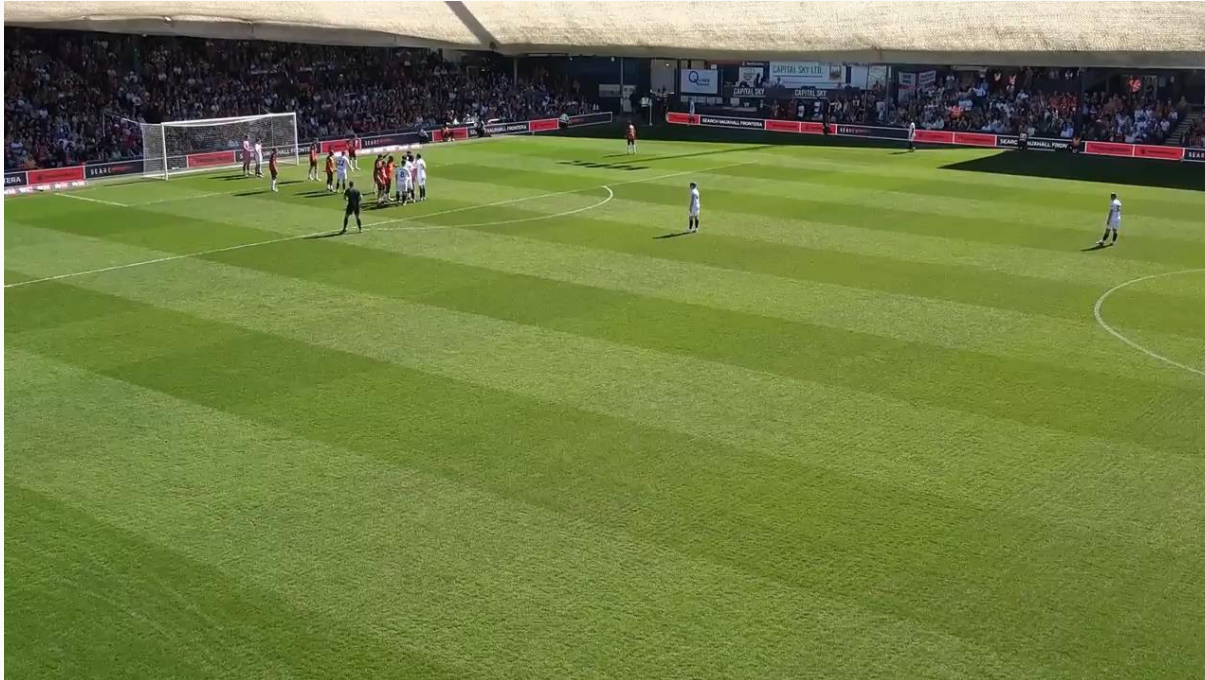
- *Bias our attack to the right (their left) in transitional moments.*
- *Specific patterns to rehearse:*
 - *Wide runner outside #32 + inside runner between #32 and #6 = 2v1 advantage*
 - *Cross-field switch from our left to right when #19 has stayed high — exploit the moment before recovery*
 - *Direct ball into the channel behind #32 when their line is high, beats his recovery pace*

SET PLAYS

Attacking routines worth scouting and defensive habits worth exploiting.

Their attacking set pieces

Corner routines, free-kick targets, and rest defence behaviour



OBSERVATION

- Inswinging corners: load the box, attack the front-post zone for first contact. #19 stays short as an alternative passing option.
- Specific routine: #18 (Banks) starts within a central penalty-spot cluster, then peels to the front post.
- Free kicks: from middle-third FKs, CB plays driven lofted ball to #19 high on the left as forward outlet.
- Their rest defence is light — typically 1 around the box edge, 1 around halfway. Counter-attack opportunity.



HOW WE HANDLE

- *Front-post zone is non-negotiable: mark the cluster aggressively, track peel runners explicitly.*
- *When their CB has time on the FK, expect a long ball to #19 — high line drops, forward outlet covers.*
- *Win the second ball and break — their light rest defence is exploitable.*

How they defend set pieces

Man-to-man marking, with two specific weaknesses



OBSERVATION

- Defend corners man-to-man, with #19 and #22 left high as transition outlets.
- Aggressive contact in the box: in one sequence, contact led to a foul and a penalty conceded. Single instance — flagged but not confirmed pattern.
- Marking lapses on second balls: after a delivery rebound, defenders can lose their marker and concede a free attacker inside the area.
- Confirmed by season data: 1st in League One (worst) for penalties conceded (9).



HOW WE HANDLE

- Load key zones aggressively — physical movements across markers may force fouls.
- Rehearse 2-3 second-ball routines this week: disguised secondary movement (decoy then real run) exploits their post-delivery marking lapses.
- Outlet awareness: rest defence must account for #19 and #22 left high as counter-attack threats.

Three Players to Plan For

The danger, the target, the connector — and how we handle each



19 • Reyes Cleary

LEFT WING

30

STARTS

7

GOALS

13

ASSISTS

81

CHANCES CREATED
(%ILE)

CLEARY — OBSERVATIONS

- Holds width on the left throughout possession; cuts inside onto right foot to shoot or play across goal.
 - Used as the long-ball target from free kicks and goal kicks - Barnsley's centre-backs and keeper repeatedly look for him on the left when going direct. His pace and high positioning are the trigger.
 - Stays high in transition rather than tracking back. This is what leaves #32 isolated and is the structural cause of their left-side vulnerability we want to exploit.
- Right-back must engage early and angle his body to force play down the line, not inside.
- Right-sided midfielder provides defensive support; do not let him receive 1v1.



32 • Josh Earl

LEFT BACK

21

STARTS

1

GOALS

6

YELLOWS

99

AERIAL DUELS
(%ILE)

EARL — OBSERVATIONS

- Inverts from left-back into a back three in possession, slotting alongside the centre-backs. His position underneath the ball gives Barnsley a secure structure on the left.
 - Strong physically and competes well in the tackle, but flat-footed in transition recovery; lacks acceleration in the first few steps.
 - Does not overlap #19 in attack - holds an inside support position rather than stretching wide. Barnsley's left side has no overlapping outlet beyond Cleary himself.
- Bias our attack to the right - target the channel outside him at speed.
- Combine wide and inside runners to force 1v1 or 2v1; he cannot manage both at pace.
- Counter-press when he has the ball in build-up - his slow first step makes him a regain target, not a progressor.



22 • Patrick Kelly

ATTACKING MID

33

STARTS

6

ASSISTS

2,902

MINUTES

71

CHANCES CREATED
(%ILE)

KELLY — OBSERVATIONS

- Drops from CAM into the middle third to receive between the lines. Becomes the free man and connects the back four to the attacking front - the trigger for Barnsley's best moves.
 - Was directly responsible for the goal-creating sequence at Luton - dropped unmarked from #32, turned, and started the move that ended in #19's shot and the rebound finish.
 - Carries real defensive responsibility - drops to support midfield and fullback areas in recovery phases. Not a luxury 10.
- A defensive midfielder follows him deep when he drops - do not pass him on between lines.
- Deny him the half-turn; force him to play backwards or sideways under pressure.
- He is also held high as an outlet when Barnsley defend our set pieces - account for him as a counter-attack threat.

APPENDIX

Further Clarification and Explanation

Predicted XI Methodology

How the selection probabilities were computed

- Sample: 45 League One matches in 2025–26 under Conor Hourihane. 6 matches excluded due to incomplete lineup data on Sofascore. Cup matches excluded to control for rotation.
- Recency weighting: each match weighted by exponential decay (0.92^n where n = matches ago). Most recent match = 1.00, oldest ≈ 0.026 . Effective weighted sample ≈ 12 matches' worth of recent selection signal.
- Why recency-weighted: Jack Shepherd has the most starts in the season (37) but hasn't started since 21 April. A naïve XI would include him; the weighted model correctly identifies de Gevigney as the current LCB.
- Confidence tiers: Nailed $\geq 80\%$ · Probable 60–80% · Rotational 40–60% · Uncertain $< 40\%$.
- Limitations: tactical observations drawn from one Hudl match. Recency weighting accounts for selection trends but cannot anticipate injuries or last-minute decisions.